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a) A demand planner is a professional responsible for analyzing data and market trends to predict how much of a product customers will buy in the future. The objective of a demand planner is ensuring that a company has enough stock on hand while also preventing a surplus of stock and waste.
b) A demand planner would need product forecasts to determine potential usage of products. A product forecast indicates the predicted quantities of goods that are expected to be purchased, having this forecast can help a demand planner know what the demand for certain products at certain times may be.
c) A forecast like this would likely be needed on a monthly basis for most standard products. In cases where the product is fast moving and has quick inventory turnover, a weekly forecast may be needed.
d) The main data files that would be required to get started on building a product forecast would be historical sales data and current product prices. These would help create a picture of how well the products sold in the past at the prices the products had then, and with the new product prices a basic forecast could be made. Other data could supplement this model, like competitor information or a record of ad campaigns, but these may not be explicitly necessary or helpful in making forecasts.
e) If I were to meet with some of the demand planners I would want to ask them how they currently make their forecasts, seeing what tools/data they use as reference for these predictions. In addition I would want to ask them how they want this to be regionally determined, for example do they want a store by store basis or a state by state basis or maybe a broad entire population forecast. I would also like to know when they want these forecasts, weekly or monthly, and at what time of the month or week they want to receive these forecasts.
f) To demonstrate the reliability of these forecasts, I would compare the predictions that the forecasting model would have made in past time intervals with what did happen using backcasting to simulate what the forecasts would have been for those instances. By showing the reliability of the model in past months I could show that the model can be trusted for future months.
g) To productionize the models, the data would need to be properly maintained and optimally in the same place as the model. This data would need to be properly labeled and formatted to ensure that there is no confusion or potential mistakes. It is important that the data is properly maintained to avoid model crashes or inaccurate predictions once the model has been productionized.
h) I would guess that they would want to receive this information in an emailed excel spreadsheet. This would give them the information that they are looking for in a familiar format that is easily accessible and immediately arrives in their inbox. This would prevent unnecessary dashboard usage and allow them to have the information they are looking for without extra delays.
i) I used a variety of different sources for this question, for definitions I used Wikipedia, and for business information I used the Medium and User Solutions. For the rest of the questions I used the best of my knowledge for the respective situations.